



REMOTE

Office Not Required

Jason Fried & David Heinemeier Hansson

The Big "So What"



The book covers the **benefits of remote work, the perceived obstacles, and practical tips for companies or employees who are considering or doing remote work.** It builds on the authors' experience in running 37signals, a successful software company.

Introduction



Working remotely hasn't been a real option till recently, due to technological advancement (e.g. documents and screen sharing, instant messages etc.). People no longer need to live in the city to have access to information, entertainment and resources – these are accessible from anywhere in the world. In fact, having the flexibility to travel anywhere will be the new luxury.

Remote work brings win-win benefits for employers and employees:



Productive time: A typical day at the office is filled with many interruptions. Working remotely provides stretches of **uninterrupted time to get meaningful work done.**



Save on commuting. If you save 1.5 hours of commute each work day, you can **save 300-400 hours per year.**



Flexibility: Remote working, once set up properly, **frees up employees from a fixed 9am-5pm schedule** – they can decide how to distribute their time most effectively within the stipulated parameters. Companies also have flexibility in choosing the right formula that work for them e.g. you can have parts of the workforce working remotely, or have most staff working remotely part of the time.



Cost savings with better outcomes. Besides **cost savings** (e.g. cutting down office space, removing redundancies), remote

KEY QUOTES

"Remote work is about setting your team free to be the best it can be, wherever that might be."

"Office not required" isn't just the future – it's in the present.. Now is your chance to catch up."

"The new luxury is the luxury of freedom and time. Once you've had a taste of that life, no corner office or fancy chef will be able to drag you back."

"The ability to be alone with your thoughts is... one of the key advantages of working remotely."

"Soon you'll see that it's the work – not the clock – that matters."

"Remote work speeds up the process of getting the wrong people off the bus and the right people on board."

working brings **better quality of life, access to the best talents** etc. It also forces the company to **evaluate people based on the work they produce**, rather than other considerations that don't really matter - it becomes clear who is performing and who isn't.



Keeping great talent. Companies **no longer have to let go of great talent** just because they can't be in the same office due to personal reasons like family/health. Talents who work away from the hubs also tend to be **happier in their work** and are less likely to be poached by the competitor next door.

Dealing with the Concerns & Excuses

There are **several common concerns** about remote work that are just excuses if they are examined closely.



No face-to-face brainstorming and breakthroughs. Breakthroughs and brilliant ideas can indeed emerge when the right people are in a room together. But, too many meetings will only overwhelm your team, and people typically have no time to follow up on so many good ideas. **When you ration the number of in-person meetings, they can actually become special and more productive.**



What if they loaf on the job? People who choose to loaf can do it in the office too. The solution is to **hire only people you can trust**. People tend to live up or down to your expectations, so if you trust them to excel without close supervision, they may prove you right.



The home is full of distractions. Distractions can be managed by **setting up the work environment properly**. In fact, the best antidote to distractions is stimulating and fulfilling work - if you find yourself/your employees unmotivated or distracted, **review whether the work is well-defined or meaningful in the first place.**



It's not as secure. It is a myth that only the office is secure, since most laptops (which people bring out of the office) are unencrypted to begin with. In fact, having everyone work from one office could mean having a Single Point of Failure (SPoF) if a major disaster hits the office. If people can

KEY QUOTES

"Saving money on labor is definitely not a valid reason to invite the hassle, but access to one-of-a-kind talent just might be."

"How many breakthrough ideas can a company actually digest? Far fewer than you imagine."

"Coming to office just means that people have to put on pants. There's no guarantee of productivity."

"Either learn to trust the people you're working with or find some other people to work with."

"The number one counter to distractions is interesting, fulfilling work.... Most people want to work, so long as it is stimulating and fulfilling."

securely perform online banking and purchases, **they can securely work from a remote location**. The authors share a list of good security measures adopted by 37signals (e.g. using hard-drive encryption and disabling automatic login).



Being accessible to customers. Rather than have someone sit by the phone from 9am-5pm to answer clients' calls, you can **adjust the customer service hours/staff people through shifts** so the entire day can be covered by remote staff.



But the big businesses don't do it... Many big businesses are still operating ineffectively, and this actually presents an **opportunity for smaller businesses to differentiate themselves**. There are also already a growing number of multi-national companies that are embracing remote working (e.g. IBM, Accenture, eBay).



Our size or industry is different... To debunk this excuse, the authors list a **wide range of industries and companies** (e.g. AT&T, Intel, McKinsey & Co, Unilever) whose people regularly work remotely.



The culture will be affected. Culture isn't about people hanging out together. It is the "spoken and unspoken values and actions of the organization" e.g. how we treat stakeholders, the quality we uphold. **Remote work actually forces companies to have a strong culture that can be clearly articulated and communicated** to new staff.



Non-remote staff may get jealous. Different jobs have different requirements and **not all are suitable for remote working** (e.g. delivery services). Most staff can understand that. Where possible, let people choose how they prefer to work and assess them based on the work completed (rather than location of completion).



I need an answer now! When other colleagues are easily accessible in the same office, we may fall into the bad habit of bothering them for anything, at any time, disrupting personal productivity. This is one of the biggest transitions when shifting to remote working. **Learn to question if an answer is really needed immediately:**

- 80% of your questions are usually **not time sensitive**: Use emails.

KEY QUOTES

"Creating security protocols and algorithms is the computer equivalent of rocket science, but taking advantage of them isn't... These days, security for your devices is just simple good sense, like putting on your seat belt."

"You're all in the game to find the best way to work: the most productive and happiness-inducing setup wins."

"Once you're ASAP-free... you'll be amazed at how your former self was able to get anything done in the face of constant inperson interruptions."

- 15% of your questions may need a **response in the next few minutes**: Use instant messages.
- Only 5% of your questions will likely need **immediate answers**: Pick up the phone and the answer is a phone-call away.



Losing control. This is one of the most difficult challenges to overcome, as the fear of losing control is usually primal or subconscious in nature. **Start small** (e.g. have someone work from home for just 1 day, then 2 days) to show that things won't fall apart, then scale up gradually from there.



Past investment in the office. The money spent on the current office **is a sunk-cost and cannot be recovered**. Focus instead on creating new productivity, in or out of the office.

Tips for Successful Remote Collaboration

There are real trade-offs involved in remote work, including reduced face-to-face time and the loss of imposed structure and regiment. This calls for greater personal commitment and new work frames. The **key is to maximise the benefits and minimize the drawbacks**.



Create overlap in work hours. This is important to avoid collaboration delays and to help remote workers to feel part of a team. The authors recommend **about 4 hours of overlap** across time zones (e.g. 11am to 7pm in Copenhagen and 8am to 5pm in Chicago, local time), so there's a balance between time for collaboration and flexibility for staff.



Ensure key resources are shared. Use shared calendars, shared drives etc. to ensure that all important materials are "out in the open" and not stuck in someone's computer. **Use screen-sharing tools** (e.g. WebEx, GoToMeeting), so staff can interact with the same materials, just like seeing it on the same computer or projector screen.



Create a "virtual water cooler". Create chat rooms where people can "hang out" **virtually and interact throughout the day** on any work or non-work issue, just like how they would at a staff pantry or a water cooler in the office.

KEY QUOTES

"Working remotely isn't without complication or occasional sacrifice. It's about making things better for more people more of the time."

"To instill a sense of company cohesion and to share forward motion, everyone needs to feel they're in the loop."

"Progress is a joy best shared with co-workers."

"When you can't see someone all day long, the only thing you have to evaluate is the work...it's clear who in the company is pulling their weight and who isn't."



Keep people in the loop. Create a platform where people can share their latest progress and goals targets, celebrate accomplishments and feel **part of a common goal**. For example, you can create a weekly discussion thread on “What have you been working on?”



Focus on the work. Evaluate people based on their work, rather than charisma, duration/ location of their work etc.



Ramping it up. Working remotely doesn't have to involve an overseas staff. **It simply means not being in the office from 9am-5pm.** Your staff can be working from a café downstairs or at the library across the road.

It is a good idea to start testing out remote arrangements for at least 3 months, by allowing local staff to work remotely, and/or with 1-2 days of remote work a week. When you are ready, you can increase the frequency and/ or move into truly remote overseas working. You can also consider **hybrid strategies** with some employees working in the office and others at home.



Minimise the M&Ms (Meetings & Managers). In the remote-working world, we still need to have meetings and managers (to plan and monitor output). However with an online “paper trail”, we can easily cut down on the M&Ms.



Critical mass. Adjustments and teething pains are expected during the transition, and people must be committed to iron out the issues. It won't work if only 1-2 people start the arrangement while the rest carry on business as usual. You need a sizeable group of people, including important stakeholders, to try it out.



Build trust with clients:

- Highlight upfront (during the pitch) that you are based in a different location
- Voluntarily provide references to show you have nothing to hide
- Show them your work regularly, so they can see the progress/results
- Be extremely available - return calls, emails, messages etc.
- Let them be involved/ feel a part of your project by including them in your shared calendars etc.

KEY QUOTES

“Meetings should be like salt - sprinkled carefully to enhance a dish, not poured recklessly over every forkful. Too much salt destroys a dish. Too many meetings can destroy morale and motivation.”

“Give remote work a real chance or don't bother at all. It's okay to start small, but make sure it's meaningful.”

Hiring and Keeping Remote Workers



Find the best internationally. Don't limit yourself to local talent – look for the best people internationally. An international team/presence can broaden your company's perspectives and serve as a selling point with clients.



Equal pay for quality. Even if you hire someone from a city with lower cost of living, make sure you pay them an equivalent amount to those staff from the big cities. Don't use remote work as an option to skimp on salaries.



Use test projects/contracts: To truly assess a candidate's suitability, it's a good practice to do "pre-hiring", i.e. hire the potential candidate for a mini project (representative of the work they're being hired for) for 1-2 weeks, before making the hiring decision. Contract work is also a great way for both the hirer and hire to assess the remote work relationship and mutual fit.



Legalities & Finances. You need to consider the legal, taxation, accounting and foreign exchange implications of hiring overseas talents. Generally, taxes kick in once you have an overseas office or a taxable presence in that country/ state. A simpler way to start may be to hire the talents as contractors (perks and benefits can be built into the fees), or even engage lawyers or accountants who can advise you on the best setup.



It's the work that matters. When hiring remote workers, the work matters most. Rather than depend on personality assessments/quizzes, ask to see past work, or present real-world problems and have the candidate answer them as part of their job application.



Good writing skills. Much of the communication in remote work is done over email, hence good writing skills are important.



Meet them in person. Both talent and character matter. To determine cultural fit, the authors recommend flying 2-3 final candidates in for a casual chat and to hang around the office to meet and interact with the team. That way, the staff can assess if they "like" the person and vice versa. Once hired,

KEY QUOTES

"The world has never been smaller and markets have never been more open. Don't be a cultural or geographical hermit."

"Remember, doing great work with great people is one of the most durable sources of happiness we humans can tap into. Stick with it."

"Your star designer out in the sticks is just as valuable (maybe more so) to the team as those working from the big-city home office. Make sure she feels that way."

"Given how hard it is to find great people, you should be doing your utmost to keep them."

"When you're seeking remote workers, you have to do even more to encourage and nurture diversity and personal development. It's a small price to pay for a more interesting workplace and to keep people engaged for the long term."

it's useful for the new recruits to spend a few weeks in the office first, so they can understand the company, its people and processes, before returning home.



Compensate for the distance. To ensure that relationships can survive the physical distance, it is important to **hire the right people (from a social perspective)**. Strictly no bad vibes, drama or politicking should be condoned. As an employer, you should also create opportunities to **expand the diversity of "human experience" and create opportunities for personal development**, e.g. encouraging or sponsoring trips and activities to create memorable experiences and/or develop new skills.

Managing Remote Workers

The rise of remote work is inevitable, and you should **start setting up for it as early as possible**. When managing remote workers:



Look out for overwork. When passionate people work from home, they risk working round the clock and getting burnt out. **Help employees to set a healthy boundary** by developing a "culture of reasonable expectations", thinking in terms of productivity (not work hours), and consciously "checking in" and "checking out" of work.



Use scarcity to your advantage. What is scarce tends to be valued more. Face-to-face interactions are scarce in remote work, hence people tend to look forward to and make better use of the opportunities when they arise. **Don't be afraid to reduce the amount of face-to-face interactions, and you'll see their value go up.**



Manage what matters. Managers should ideally know what needs to be done, know how to split the work into meaningful chunks, understand potential delays, help solve problems, and put the right people on the right projects.



Meet-ups & sprints. It is important for the team to meet up in person occasionally say, twice a year. It creates an opportunity for people to be involved in charting the company's direction, get reacquainted with one another as individuals, or even do a sprint to finish a project.

KEY QUOTES

"A manager's natural instinct is to worry about his workers not getting enough work done, but the real threat is that too much will likely get done."



Lessons from open source. Open source platforms like Wordpress and Linux are built from contributions by thousands of users worldwide. From their experience, we learn several lessons:

- **Intrinsic motivation:** people who are passionate about their work don't need to be managed.
- **All out in the open:** Because all the information is out in the open, anyone who wishes to help out can.
- **Meeting occasionally:** Most successful open-source projects grow to a point where they can support their own conferences or general sessions to allow people to meet up in person.



Remove the roadblocks, Level the playing field. To create true flexibility to work anytime, anywhere, **empower people to make decisions and give them access to every resource they need.** This requires trust that your remote workers will be reasonable and responsible. Invest in good intercom systems, shared desktop apps etc. so your remote workers can participate meaningfully in office discussions. **Ensure everyone is seeing the same picture.**



One-on-ones. Do regular "check-ins" or one-on-one calls with your remote employees every month or every few months. **A casual "how are things with you" call** can help to keep the connection and unearth small things that may otherwise go unnoticed.

Life as a Remote Worker

Remote work brings flexibility and new lifestyle options, but also requires some adjustment in thinking and behaviour:



Cabin fever. Remote work should not translate into isolation and solitude. As a remote worker, you can set aside quality time with family and friends, and /or step out of your home occasionally to create opportunities for human interaction.



Ergonomics. Remote working means you have the freedom to work anywhere. To make it viable in the long-term, consider your equipment (chairs, tables, screens) to take care of your body anatomy, and vary your sitting/standing positions so you're not cooped up for long periods in the same positions.

KEY QUOTES

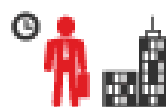
"If you let them, humans have an amazing power to live up to your high expectations of reasonableness and responsibility."

"Flexibility is your friend here. Remote isn't binary. It's not here or there, this or that."

"Just because you work remotely most of the time doesn't mean you have to, or should, work remotely all of the time."



Staying healthy. Remote working may result in even lesser opportunity for movement and exercise, so you'll need to deliberately build in reasons to move around in the day.



Build a routine. Most people require some form of routine to be productive. You can use specific routines or cues (e.g. change of attire) to switch into "work mode", divide the day into chunks (e.g. "serious work", "catch-up" etc.), or use specific parts of your house for different activities. You can also use **hybrid approaches** that best suit your work/team e.g. remote arrangements in the morning (for focused work) and going to office in the afternoon (for collaborative work).



Draw the lines. To avoid overworking, create a greater distinction between work and play e.g. have different computers, device or accounts for work and personal use.



Find your space(s). Remote work allows you to **change your scenery**/work environment regularly, creating opportunities for new ideas. Remember that **working alone in the presence of others** (e.g. at a vibrant café with Wifi) can sometimes induce greater productivity than if you are totally alone.



Stay motivated. A person's level of motivation can be a gauge of the quality of work and the work environment. If you find yourself becoming unmotivated, have the courage to speak up and diagnose the issue. To make sure you are not neglected or ignored by your company, you can either make more noise or show exceptional work.

Conclusion

Like how the internet has transformed the way we communicate and do business, remote work is here to stay and will become more prevalent. The right time to get onboard is now.

Other Useful Details in the Book to Look Out For



The book reads somewhat like a collection of blog posts. Fried and Hansson share many examples of how they have implemented remote work at 37signals, such as their security measures, how

KEY QUOTES

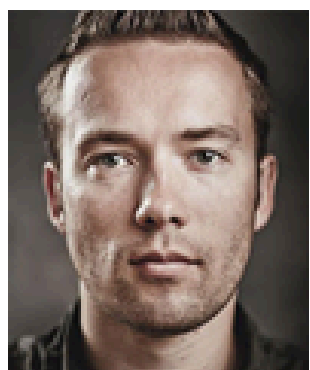
"The only reliable way to muster motivation is by encouraging people to work on the stuff they like and care about, with people they like and care about."

"Motivation is pivotal to healthy lives and healthy companies. Make sure you're minding it."

"Remote work is here, and it's here to stay. The only question is whether you'll be part of the early adopters, the early majority, the late majority, or the laggards."

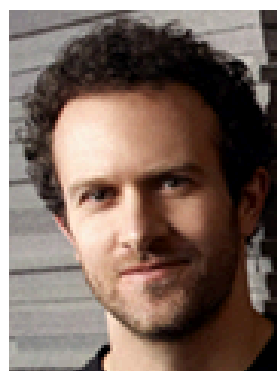
they promote staff interaction and a healthy lifestyle, and how they support their staff with a company credit card and flexible vacations. They also provided a list of tools that they use in the “Remote Toolbox”. These examples and tools may not be applicable to all companies, but provide ideas of what can be done.

About the Authors



David Heinemeier Hansson (born 1979) is a Danish programmer & author. He is best known for his creation of the Ruby on Rails web development framework, for which he was recognized by Google and O'Reilly with the Hacker of the Year award in 2005.

Hansson graduated from the Copenhagen Business School with a bachelor's degree in Computer Science and Business Administration, before moving to Chicago, USA. He became a partner at Basecamp (formerly 37signals) together with Jason Fried. Jason Fried is the co-founder & CEO at Basecamp.com. He's the co-author of Getting Real, Remote, and NYT Bestseller REWORK. Hansson co-wrote Agile Web Development with Rails with Dave Thomas, as well as Getting Real, Rework, and Remote with Jason Fried.



KEY QUOTES
